in prayer, next to the words “Free Palestine” scrawled in red paint—would define his trip. Prime Minister Netanyahu responded quickly by asking the pontiff to amend his itinerary and include a stop at the national memorial for victims of terrorism on Mount Herzl.

Politics aside, many Christians in Israel saw the visit as a welcome show of solidarity with their embattled coreligionists across the region. It ended amicably, with an invitation for the Israeli and Palestinian presidents, Shimon Peres and Mahmoud Abbas, to join him at the Vatican on 8 June and pray for peace. (The prayer summit would be Peres’ last major act on the world stage; it would be an unfortunate coda, given his reputation as a peacemaker, since war would begin again a few weeks later.)

Yet there was more controversy when, around the same time, the Israeli army sent a batch of “voluntary draft notices” to Christians. They were under no obligation to respond, but the army thought that sending the letters, rather than simply waiting for Christians to show up at the induction center, might boost enlistment. Khalloul, needless to say, supported the move. So did Father Gabriel Naddaf, a Greek Orthodox priest who had become a controversial figure for his own outspoken pro-Israel views. He was a frequent guest at the Knesset (until mid-2016, when he was accused of soliciting sexual favors from children). But it caused a major upset in other parts of the Christian community, with protests in Nazareth and other cities.

“[It’s] a good opportunity to try the old Zionist policy of divide-and-rule,” said Basel Ghattas, a Palestinian member of the Knesset, a Christian himself, and a critic of the plan. “They’ve created an argument within the Christian community. There is a huge debate, a huge crisis.” (Ghattas would be arrested two years later on suspicion of smuggling mobile phones to Palestinian prisoners in Israeli jails. He lost his seat after pleading guilty, and was sentenced to jail time.)

About 21 per cent of Israel’s 8.2 million citizens are members of the Arab minority. Jewish politicians and the Israeli media often describe them, simply, as the “Arab sector” (*mizgar aravi*), a term that elides the vast religious, political and cultural differences within the community. Their numbers include 180,000 Christians—roughly 2 per cent of the national population, making them the third-largest religious group, behind Jews and Muslims. Israeli officials occasionally describe their country as the only one in the Middle East with a growing Christian population, which is untrue.